licences were prone to damage and loss, often requiring applicants to endure the inefficient system all over again.

THE EASE OF LIVING

The West Bengal transport department has revamped the process of obtaining a driving licence, introducing a streamlined, largely online system lauded for its simplicity and transparency. The new procedure begins with an online application, instantly generating a digital learner's licence. After a mandatory one-month learning period, applicants can book their driving test slots online, reducing delays. A single visit to the Regional Transport Office (RTO) for the driving test leads to the issuance of a provisional licence. For Rs 200, applicants receive their final, smart card-based licence within seven working days, delivered directly by post. These smart cards, equipped with QR codes and chips, minimise paperwork and promise future-ready functionality. The overhaul has eliminated multiple RTO visits and the need for middlemen, marking a significant step toward transparency.

An added highlight is the department's commitment to timely service. If a licence does not reach an applicant on time, an investigation is promptly initiated, and resolutions are provided without undue delay. To ensure inclusivity, 3,561 Bangla Sahayata Kendras (BSKs) across 23 districts assist applicants unfamiliar with online processes. These single-window platforms simplify access to state services, ensuring no one is left behind. This proactive approach has bolstered public trust in the system. While aligned with the Motor Vehicles Act of 2019, Bengal's system differs slightly. Unlike other states, where government-recognised driving centres conduct tests, Bengal mandates an RTO visit for the test. However, the state has optimised this requirement, trying its best to make this single visit seamless and hassle-free.

Beyond licences, Bengal's transport department now offers 102 "faceless services", including vehicle registration, tax payments and permit renewals—all completed online. By eliminating in-person visits, these services have revolutionised convenience and transparency. The system's impact is evident in its numbers: between June 1, 2023, and January 14, 2025, the department has issued 1.54 million smart card-based driving licences and 2.12 million smart card-based registration certificates. Together, these initiatives, claims the government, have led to a revenue boost of around Rs 50 crore to the state exchequer. Transport minister Snehasis Chakraborty highlights the scope of this transformation: "With 16.7 million registered vehicles, digitising services is a monumental task. Yet, 70-80 per cent of the system has been streamlined, and efforts are ongoing to address the remaining gaps. Our goal is fast, transparent and efficient public services." So far, his department seems to be on the right track. ■

Beyond licences, Bengal's transport dept now offers 102 "faceless services", including vehicle registration and permit renewals—all completed online

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Don't have to face red tapism anymore"

Years ago, Uddalak Bose got a driving licence—printed on a piece of paper—issued through a private driving school in Gurugram. To his surprise, when he went to get it renewed in 2023, no government record could corroborate its authenticity. This left Bose, now a banker based in Kolkata, reliant on cabs and public transport until he could obtain a new licence—this time through West Bengal's newly streamlined system.

UDDALAK BOSE, 44
Banker, Kolkata



Bose applied online, receiving a learner's licence immediately. Within a month, he passed the driving test and was issued a provisional licence. Despite encountering minor issues while accessing the portal, he completed the process mostly "hassle-free". "One doesn't have to face the infamous red tapism anymore," says Bose, though he points out that navigating the RTO office and portal without "assistance" is still a bit challenging. ■